

Trump-Xi summit: Low bar, high stakes

- We expect limited stabilization, with strategic stability a key measure of success.
- Iran and strategic waterways offer the clearest geopolitical upside, despite tensions over China's links to Tehran.
- The economic package should exceed May but remain narrow: tariff restraint, a renewed rare earth truce, limited chip licensing, additional purchases, selective investment.
- On AI, a risk-management dialogue is more likely than a binding governance agreement.
- The likely outcome is strategic accommodation within managed decoupling – not partnership or a grand bargain.

President Xi is expected to travel to Washington around 23-25 September for his second summit with President Trump this year. It would be his first US state visit since September 2015. The intervening 11 years have transformed the relationship: tariff frictions became trade and technology wars, sanctions and blacklists expanded, supply chains began to separate, and tensions over energy security intensified.

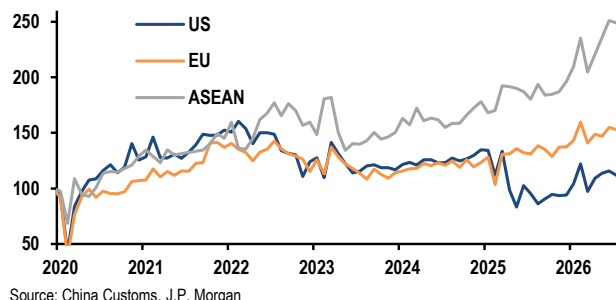
The return to a full state visit carries unusual symbolic weight. Ceremonial pomp will allow both leaders to project success at home and abroad. Yet the substantive test is modest: sustaining the 'constructive relationship of strategic stability' agreed in May: continued dialogue, controlled competition and damage control, not partnership or a grand bargain.

Strategic stability: damage control valuable

The May consensus set a deliberately low bar. China describes many of its close bilateral ties as comprehensive or strategic partnerships, but neither side is prepared to use that language here. The formulation implies coexistence, communication, and limits on escalation, not strategic trust or aligned interests.

Interdependence nevertheless creates a form of economic deterrence. US goods and services trade with China totaled US\$494.6bn in 2025, including a US\$202.7bn goods deficit and a US\$34.4bn services surplus. The two economies also retain different chokepoints – US leverage in advanced technology and finance, and Chinese leverage in critical-mineral processing and manufacturing supply chains. Either side can impose substantial costs, but escalation also damages its own firms, consumers, markets and strategic supplies. Mutual harm does not prevent coercion; it raises the threshold for uncontrolled escalation and strengthens the case for guard-rails.

Figure 1: China export by destinations
Index, sa, 2019=100



The relationship has been neither quiet nor peaceful since May. Reciprocal blacklisting, export controls, procurement restrictions and sanctions show how quickly disputes can spread across sectors. The sequencing gap remains central: Beijing argues that political stability must precede durable agreements; Washington wants purchases, market access and implementation first to validate engagement. Xi's attendance at the Shanghai Cooperation Organization (SCO) summit in Bishkek on 1 September and the BRICS summit in New Delhi on 12-13 September reinforced China's emphasis on multi-lateralism, sanctions restraint, energy security and resilient supply chains. The summit must bridge these approaches: reassurance for China and monitorable outcomes for the US.

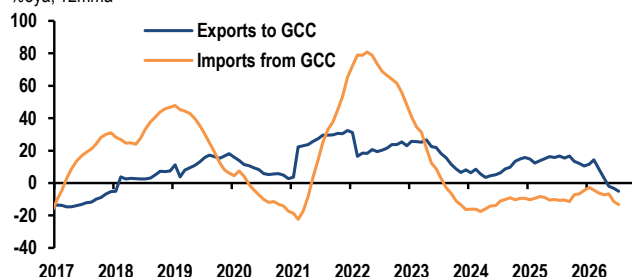
Weekend preparatory talks between US Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent and Chinese Vice Premier He Lifeng will test whether the package is ready for leader-level decisions. Iran sanctions and China's financial links to Tehran are expected to feature alongside trade, rare earths, agriculture and artificial intelligence. The aim is to narrow differences and leave only the most political trade-offs for Trump and Xi; deadlock would raise the risk of ceremony without substance.

On 24 August 2026, the US Treasury launched Operation Economic Outcast – described by Secretary Scott Bessent as an 'Economic D-Day' – moving the dispute closer to the financial core. US measures against Iran-linked networks show how enforcement can reach Chinese and Hong Kong SAR institutions even when Iran is the underlying target. Washington will seek tighter Chinese controls; Beijing will seek proportionality, advance consultation and protection for legitimate commerce. A practical understanding could pair clearer evidence and remediation procedures with verifiable Chinese action against named entities, reducing the risk that sanctions trigger broader financial decoupling.

Geopolitical upside: strategic waterways

The Middle East offers the clearest geopolitical bargain. After a month of relative calm, US-Iran fighting re-escalated in early September. Risks then widened to Bab el-Mandeb: the Houthis seized Mocha on 10 September and advanced to Perim Island on 11 September, although Yemeni government forces later recovered some nearby territory. Oil flows through the Strait of Hormuz averaged 21.2mn barrels per day in 2025 before falling to 4.9mn in 2Q26; Bab el-Mandeb flows rose from 5.6mn barrels per day in 1Q26 to 8.1mn in 2Q26 as shipments were diverted from Hormuz. The near-simultaneous pressure on both chokepoints raises energy, freight and insurance costs along the Gulf-Red Sea-Suez route. On 15 September, Brent spot crude reached US\$130.80 per barrel, US retail regular gasoline US\$4.37 per gallon and diesel US\$6.31 per gallon.

Figure 2: China's trade with GCC - growth rate
%oya, 12mma



Source: China Customs, J.P. Morgan

Both sides want the routes open, but bring different leverage. Washington has greater military and sanctions capacity; Beijing has deeper commercial ties and political access to Tehran. The May meeting established broad common ground on preventing an Iranian nuclear weapon and reopening Hormuz, but stopped short of observable commitments. A September package that converts China's access into action – support for a ceasefire, pressure to keep strategic waterways open and tighter controls on identified financial networks – could be the summit's most consequential upside. It would give Trump a visible geopolitical achievement before the mid-term elections while protecting China's energy security and legitimate commercial interests, potentially in exchange for narrower US secondary-sanctions spillovers.

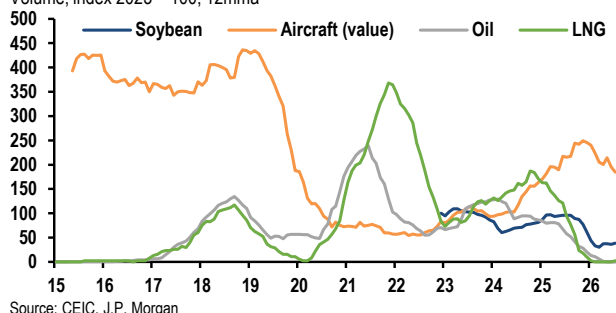
North Korea is a narrower test of China's diplomatic value. Xi's 8-9 June state visit to Pyongyang strengthened high-level China-North Korea ties. China may be able to test interest in renewed US-North Korea contact and help, but the absence of substantive progress means facilitation is more plausible than a nuclear bargain.

Taiwan is Beijing's principal concern. China will seek stronger US language against Taiwan independence and near-term restraint in the timing or scale of arms sales. A formal policy shift is unlikely, but calibrated reassurances could give Beijing political justification to cooperate elsewhere. For Washington, the balance is to reduce near-term escalation risk without weakening deterrence or appearing to bargain over Taiwan.

More deals likely, but no grand bargain

On tariffs, we expect managed restraint, not normalization. Legacy Section 301 duties generally remain at 25% on Lists 1-3 and 7.5% on List 4A, with higher rates on selected strategic products; product-level treatment still depends on the relevant tariff classification. The 178 current exclusions remain effective through November 9, 2026. USTR separately opened a Section 301 investigation into structural excess capacity in manufacturing on 11 March 2026, but has not announced an additional tariff rate. Washington could use the investigation as leverage for verified purchases, market access and action on excess capacity; Beijing will seek renewed exclusions and restraint on new China-specific measures. A credible September deliverable would be an initial US-China Board of Trade product list for reciprocal tariff modifications, with an implementation timetable and monitoring mechanism. This would support a negotiated standstill, not remove the core tariff framework.

Figure 3: China imports of select US goods
Volume, index 2023 = 100, 12mma



Source: CEIC, J.P. Morgan

Purchases are the easiest complement because they are visible and politically useful. The May agreement included an initial purchase of 200 Boeing aircraft and at least US\$17bn a year of US agricultural products in 2026-28. The September package could add aircraft, spare parts, jet engines and maintenance services, alongside oil and liquefied natural gas. These deals would support tariff restraint and give Trump identifiable wins, but would not resolve the US\$202.7bn goods deficit recorded in 2025.

Investment will remain limited and conditional. A credible September deliverable would be to launch the US-China

Board of Investment with screening criteria for non-sensitive projects, named contact points, review deadlines and a small pilot pipeline. National-security screening would remain intact; the gain would be greater predictability for selected transactions, not a broad reopening.

Tech and critical minerals: another truce, no settlement

Technology remains the hardest file because bargaining power is asymmetric across the supply chain. The United States controls advanced chips and design tools; China dominates critical-mineral processing. Since January 13, the US Bureau of Industry and Security has reviewed Nvidia H200, AMD MI325X and comparable chip licenses case by case, subject to capacity, compliance and third-party testing safeguards. This creates scope for approved sales and end-use safeguards, but not a dismantling of controls.

Figure 4: US-China sanction/unreliable entity lists



China accounted for about 91% of global magnet rare earth separation and refining in 2024, making processing the principal bottleneck. J.P. Morgan estimates that US neodymium-praseodymium production costs are about 69% above China's when regulatory and waste costs are included. China's April 2025 heavy rare earth licensing measures, followed by broader controls later that year, demonstrated that interdependence is no longer a one-sided US advantage. The subsequent Busan understanding suspended the broader October measures but left the earlier licensing regime in place. The most plausible technology outcome is another renewable one-year extension, clearer licensing and limited semiconductor approvals – a truce that reduces disruption while preserving leverage.

AI may emerge as a separate risk-management track, but the scope for agreement is narrowing. Trump's 'whoever wins AI wins' framing and Beijing's parallel emphasis on technological leadership reinforce a zero-sum contest over chips, models and standards, pushing safety risks down the agenda. Joint leadership on global AI governance is therefore unlikely. The more plausible outcome is limited dialogue on AI-enabled cyberattacks, incident notification and voluntary laboratory protocols, rather than binding rules.

Road ahead: strategic accommodation within managed decoupling

Domestic timing reinforces the case for a limited agreement. Trump wants visible gains ahead of the US mid-term elections – farm purchases, aircraft and jet-engine orders, and progress on geopolitical conflicts. Xi will benefit from external stability before China's March 2027 "Two Sessions" – the National People's Congress (NPC) and Chinese People's Political Consultative Conference (CPPCC) – and the 21st Party Congress. China recorded a merchandise trade surplus of about US\$1.19tn in 2025, according to customs data, strengthening Beijing's bargaining position but also raising the value of avoiding a new tariff or sanctions shock.

Against this backdrop, we expect limited but useful stabilization: a one-year rare earth truce extension, selected tariff exclusions, limited semiconductor licensing, additional purchases, and investment and sanctions guardrails. Core tariffs, technology controls, investment screening and supply-chain diversification would remain. The summit would stabilize managed decoupling, not reverse it.

Strategic stability will require a continuing process, not a one-off summit. The diplomatic calendar may offer two further opportunities later this year: the Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation (APEC) Leaders' Meeting in Shenzhen on 18-19 November and the G20 Leaders' Summit in Miami on 14-15 December. Further Trump-Xi meetings are not confirmed, but repeated leader-level contact would allow both sides to review implementation, renew temporary arrangements and contain disputes before they spread across sectors.

That would count as a success: communication remains open, critical routes remain accessible and disputes are contained before they cascade across sectors. Regular leader-level review would turn episodic damage control into a more durable framework for strategic stability.

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